The Green Place

Yara comes to Kijani



Kijani at dawn - the temple, the tree shelters, and the river.

Yara is seventeen, half human and half Vey'kar.
Her mother Oya has brought her deep into the jungle
to a village no human is meant to find.

Chapter 1

The trail disappeared behind them on purpose.

Yara noticed it the third time it happened. Her mother walked a few steps into a wall of green, pressed a broad leaf back into place with the flat of her hand, and dragged a fallen branch across the soft earth where their feet had been. Just like that, there was no path. There had never been a path. Anyone coming after them would find jungle, and only jungle. Yara shifted her pack higher on her shoulders and watched her mother's hands work - unhurried, thorough, leaving nothing for strangers' eyes. Part of her was impatient to arrive. Another part, quieter, understood: this slow care was how her mother said she would keep them safe, without ever saying it aloud.

Yara let out a slow breath through her nose, her shoulders dropping under the pack. "Again?" Yara said. It came out flatter and more tired than she meant it to, and she pressed her lips together at once, embarrassed by how childish she sounded.

"Again," Oya said, without turning round. "And again after that. A trail that stays is a door. We do not leave doors open." Oya's hands never stopped moving as she spoke. Her voice was even, almost gentle, but her markings held a steady, watchful brightness in the shade, and Yara knew better than to argue with that brightness.

They had been walking since before the sun was properly up. Yara's legs ached in a way she was too proud to mention. The pack on her back was not even the heaviest one - Oya carried the heavy load, tools and salt and dried meat wrapped in leaves, and Oya was not breathing hard at all. That was the difference between them, one of many, and Yara had been counting the differences all morning the way she always did when she was tired. Under the tiredness sat something she did not say either: if she complained, she would sound human in exactly the way Jabari expected, and she would rather ache in silence than give him that.

Her mother was tall, even for a Vey'kar, and moved through the trees like the trees made room for her. The markings on her arms glowed faintly in the shade, blue under warm bronze skin, brightening whenever she stopped to listen. Yara's own markings were paler. If she squinted at the back of her hand, she could just about see them. If a human looked, they would probably see nothing at all. Jabari would have something to say about that. Jabari always had something to say. Yara looked down at her own hands again, flexing her fingers in the dim light, willing the faint lines to show themselves. They stayed pale. Her chest tightened with the old, familiar wish - to look, just once, unmistakably like her mother's daughter.

She pushed the thought away and concentrated on the jungle instead.

Even tired, she loved this part. The jungle talked, if you knew how to hear it, and Yara - whatever else she was - had inherited the hearing. Rain was coming, hours away yet, but she could smell it, clean and sharp above the rich smell of wet earth. Water ran somewhere to her left, over stone. Something small and quick was moving through the branches high above them, and something much larger was standing very still a long way off to the right, being a tree so hard that it gave itself away. She lifted her face as she walked, breathing it all in slowly, and for a moment the tiredness fell away. Out here, at least, her body knew what it was doing, even if she did not always know what she was.

Yara froze mid-step, one foot still raised, her ears pricked and her heart suddenly loud in her chest. "Deer?" she whispered. The whisper came out eager - too eager, she knew even as she said it.

"Boar," Oya said. "An old one. He knows we are here and he has decided we are not worth standing up for. He is right. Keep walking." Oya did not even turn her head. She said it the way she said most true things, calmly and without doubt, one hand resting lightly on a tree trunk as she listened past Yara's hearing. There was no teasing in it, only certainty, and Yara felt both steadied and small at once.

Yara grinned at the back of her mother's head. Her senses were strong - but her mother's were stronger, the way a river is stronger than a stream, and one day, Oya had promised, her own would deepen. One day. A lot of Yara's life lived in *one day*. Hope rose in her anyway, warm and stubborn - that one day she would hear a jungle the way her mother heard it, and no one would be able to tell her she belonged only halfway.

The light changed first. That was how she knew they were close before she was told. The green above them grew thicker, layer on layer of canopy, until the morning came through soft and gold and broken into pieces. The air tasted different too - woodsmoke, very faint, and cooking, and people. Her heart kicked. Her steps quickened without her deciding to hurry. Whatever waited under that canopy, she wanted to see it with her own eyes at last.

Yara stopped dead and lifted her head, nostrils flaring as she breathed in deep, her markings prickling faintly with excitement. "Oya," she said. "I can smell a fire."

"Good," her mother said, and for the first time all morning, Yara heard her smile. "Then smell this too. No light leaves this place. No smoke rises straight. Everything Kijani does, it does under cover. Remember it." As she spoke, Oya reached out and rested her palm briefly over Yara's hand, warm and sure, guiding her attention the way she guided everything - by touch as much as by words. Pride warmed Yara's chest, followed quickly by the weight of the warning inside it.

They stepped between two great roots, taller than Yara herself, and the jungle opened. Yara caught her breath and stopped without meaning to, one hand pressed flat against the great root beside her, as if she needed to touch something solid.

Kijani was smaller than she had pictured, and more beautiful, and it undid her completely.

She had imagined a camp. What she found was a village being born.

The temple stood at the centre of a wide clearing, old stone rising step above step, its edges trimmed with gold that caught what little sun reached the ground. Who had built it, and when, nobody had ever told her - it was simply there, older than everyone, as if the jungle had grown up around it and decided to keep it. Torches burned at its base even in daylight, small steady flames shielded under the canopy, and the smoke from them broke apart in the leaves and never rose in a line. Yara turned in a slow circle in the middle of the clearing, taking it in piece by piece, her mouth slightly open. She did not know where to look first, and that not-knowing felt like awe.

Around the temple, the village was still taking shape. Two shelters stood finished in the great trees, platforms of woven wood lashed high in the branches, with ladders and rope bridges strung between them. A third was half built, its frame open to the sky like ribs. Down on the ground, near the river that slid bright along the edge of the clearing, a hut stood with bunches of herbs drying under its roof. Yara could smell them from here - bitter, green, medicinal.

There were so few people. A family working together on the half-built shelter. An old hunter sharpening a spear by the temple steps. Two small children who stopped their game to stare at Yara with enormous amber eyes, the way children stare at anything new. Yara folded her arms tightly across herself, suddenly aware of every eye. She was the stranger here, whatever her mother called her, and the thought sat cold in her stomach.

"This is it?" she said, and then, too late, heard how it sounded. The words slipped out before she could catch them. Heat rushed into her face, her markings flickered, and she stared down at her boots, horrified at herself - she had meant wonder, and it had come out sounding like disappointment.

But Oya did not take offence. She set her heavy pack down on the temple steps and looked at the clearing the way Yara had seen her look at nothing else, ever.

Oya did not look away from the clearing as she answered. Her jaw was set, but her eyes had softened in a way Yara rarely saw, and her hand, resting on the heavy pack, opened and closed once, slowly, as if she were holding something fragile. "This is the beginning," she said. "A clan is not counted in shelters, Yara. It is counted in who stands in the clearing. More will come. Word travels, even in silence. They will find their way to us, family by family - and every one of them will need this place to still be hidden when they arrive." Listening, Yara felt the smallness of the place stop frightening her. In her mother's voice it was not a camp at all. It was a promise - and promises, from Oya, were heavy things to be standing next to.

Oya's own hut stood close to the temple, and it surprised Yara, the way so much surprised her that day. It was bigger than the others, yes - but plain. No gold. No carving over the door. Woven walls, a good roof, a hearth swept clean.

Yara said it quietly, ducking her head as she followed her mother inside, running one hand along the plain woven wall. There was no scolding in it, only surprise. "You could have the temple," Yara said.

"I could," Oya agreed. "And then every day my people would walk past their queen living in stone while they built their homes out of branches. No." She ducked under the low doorway and hung her hunting knife on its peg by the door, exactly as she had done in every home they had ever had. "I asked for a village, not a throne. If Kijani becomes a place where the leader lives apart, it has already failed, whatever else it builds." Oya's markings stayed calm and dim as she spoke, and that calm told Yara more than the words did. This was not modesty performed for an audience. Her mother truly did not want to be set above these people, and Yara felt a fierce, protective pride rise in her throat.

Yara stored that away. She stored away a lot of things her mother said. Oya spoke rarely and wasted nothing, and Yara had learned young that a sentence of her mother's could be unpacked for days.

That first evening, before the food, before anything, Oya took her up the temple steps so the whole clearing could see them, and the village - all of it, perhaps twenty people - gathered below in the torchlight. Yara's face burned. Her markings, traitors, brightened with it. She stood stiffly at her mother's side, hands clasped hard in front of her so no one would see them shake, and tried to stand the way a future keeper of rules was supposed to stand.

"The rules are not new," Oya said. Her voice was not loud. It did not need to be. "But my daughter will hear them where everyone can hear them, because one day she will be the one who keeps them." Oya stood very still as she spoke, chin lifted, her gaze moving slowly across the faces below, giving the words time to land. Yara watched her mother's hands hang loose and steady at her sides, and envied that steadiness with her whole heart.

Yara's stomach dropped straight through the stone steps.

Oya let a silence fall first, long enough for the torches to crackle and for every murmur below to die away. When she spoke again, each word was placed like a stone. "We stay hidden. That is the first law on this world, above every other. We keep our markings covered beyond the tree line. We dim our eyes. We take only the trails, and we close the trails behind us. No human finds Kijani. No human follows one of us home. Not a lost one, not a kind one, not a dying one. No one." Beside her, Yara barely breathed. She felt the law settle over the clearing - and over her most of all.

Yara looked out at the faces below her - hunters, builders, children, elders - all of them watching her instead of her mother, because she was the news. She wanted, very suddenly and very badly, not to let any of them down. It was a frightening feeling, wanting something that big. She shifted her weight from foot to foot on the stone, then made herself stop, and stood still the way her mother stood still.

"And if I am seen?" she asked, because someone had to ask it and it might as well be the person most likely to do it. "Out there. Away from here." Her voice wavered only at the end. She lifted her chin and made herself hold her mother's gaze, even as her hands twisted together behind her back.

"Then you run," Oya said. "You do not fight, you do not explain, you do not lead them here. You run until the jungle has you, and then you tell me. Whatever has happened, you tell me. Is that understood?" Oya's voice hardened on the last question, and her markings brightened sharply in the torchlight - not anger at Yara, Yara understood, but fear, quickly mastered and hidden behind command. The sight of it frightened Yara more than the words had.

Yara's throat clicked as she swallowed. "Yes." The single word came out small and tight, and she hated how small it sounded in front of everyone.

"By me alone is not enough." Oya turned her by the shoulder, gently, so she faced the clearing. "Tell them."

Yara swallowed. "I understand," she said, to twenty watching faces. "I will keep the secret." Her voice shook, but she kept it as steady as she could and looked from face to face as she spoke, so it would be a promise made to people, not just to the dark. Inside, her heart was hammering so hard she was sure Zola, somewhere below, could hear it.

Some heads nodded. Some did not. One face in particular, at the edge of the torchlight, did not move at all - and Yara marked it, the way she had marked the boar in the trees that morning, as something large standing very still.

But before she had to think about that face, an elbow dug into her ribs and a voice said, right into her ear, "You look like you are being sentenced. It is only a village, princess. Come and eat before Amara decides you need one of her teas." Zola's whisper was warm with mischief, her breath tickling Yara's ear, and the grin in her voice loosened something knotted in Yara's chest. Relief flooded her so fast it almost hurt.

Zola.

Yara turned so fast she nearly fell off the temple steps, and Zola caught her by the wrist and held her there, grinning, as if catching falling princesses was something she did every day of the week.

Zola was seventeen, fully Vey'kar, and everything Yara was not: sure-footed, sure-handed, and entirely sure the rules were mostly suggestions for other people. She was the best young tracker in Kijani - whenever Yara had visited as a child, it had been Zola who had found her, every single time, no matter where she hid. Her braids were full of bands, hunt after hunt, and she wore them the way a soldier wears medals, as if they were nothing.

"You got taller," Zola said, disgusted, looking her up and down on the walk to the fire. "That is unfair. Human blood is meant to make you smaller." Zola bumped her shoulder companionably against Yara's as they walked, her markings bright with good humour, her whole body loose and easy in a way Yara's never was among people.

Yara glanced down at her pale arms and gave a short, wry laugh, rubbing at the back of one hand with her thumb. "It made my markings smaller instead." She said it lightly, the way she said most things that stung, so it would sound like a joke instead.

Zola's grin widened. She ticked the air with one finger, already counting. "Good. More room on your arms for hunt bands. We start tomorrow at dawn. I have a list."

Yara stopped walking and stared at her, eyebrows up, a reluctant smile pulling at her mouth despite herself. "You have a *list*?"

Zola tossed the words over her shoulder without slowing, her braids swinging, daring Yara to fall behind. "I have had months to prepare, princess. Keep up." Yara hurried after her, half annoyed and half delighted, and found she was smiling properly for the first time since the temple steps.

By the fire, the woman with the herb hut set a bowl in Yara's hands before she had even sat down. Amara was in her early fifties, a healer, with clever eyes and hands that were never quite still - sorting leaves, testing a knot, feeling the edge of a cup for a crack. She looked at Yara the way the boar had not bothered to: thoroughly, and with a decision being made behind the look.

"You are tired in your shoulders," Amara said. "And you favour your left leg when you think no one watches. Tomorrow you will come to me before Zola takes you anywhere. Mentors before trackers. That was the arrangement." As she spoke, Amara's cool fingers settled briefly on Yara's shoulder and then her wrist, reading her the way other people read a face. There was no pity in her touch, only quiet knowing, and Yara felt seen in a way that was both comforting and unsettling - as if Amara already knew things about her she had not said aloud.

"She will be late," Zola said happily. "She is slow in the mornings, ask anyone." Zola pointed at Yara with her chin, eyes dancing, delighted with herself.

Yara straightened on the spot, chin up, markings flickering with indignation. "I will not be late." The words came out firmer than she felt, aimed at Zola but meant, mostly, for herself.

Amara's mouth softened. "No," she said. "I do not think you will be. Eat, child. Then sleep. Kijani will still be here in the morning - that is rather the point of it." Amara pressed the bowl more firmly into Yara's hands and gave her fingers a brief, motherly squeeze before letting go. Warmth spread through Yara that had nothing to do with the food.

The face at the edge of the torchlight came to her after the meal, when the fire had burned low and the clearing was full of that soft, full-bellied quiet that Yara had not known she was homesick for until she heard it. Yara's shoulders tightened when she saw who was coming toward her. She set her bowl down carefully, buying herself a moment, her appetite gone.

Jabari was an elder, in his late sixties, a traditional hunter of the old world and - long ago, before Yara was born - Oya's own teacher. He was not a large man, for a Vey'kar. He did not need to be. He looked at people the way ice looks at a river.

"Walk with me," he said. It was not a request in any useful sense. Jabari did not wait to see if she followed. He simply turned and walked, hands clasped behind his back, certain she would come. After a heartbeat, stomach sinking, Yara did.

They walked the edge of the clearing, where the training ground lay open and empty in the dark. Yara could see every root and stone of it, her night eyes open wide. That, at least, she could do properly.

"Your mother speaks of you as an heir," Jabari said. "I taught your mother. I know what a hunter looks like before the making, and I know what softness looks like too. You have lived among humans more than any child of this clan. You hide your markings - " he glanced at her pale arms, and his lip moved, " - although there is, I grant you, less to hide." He kept his eyes ahead as he spoke, never once looking at her, and somehow that was worse than anger would have been. Yara walked beside him with her fists clenched at her sides, each word landing like a small, cold stone in her chest.

Heat went through Yara so fast her markings flared, which was the worst possible answer and they both knew it.

"When your trial comes," Jabari said mildly, watching them glow, "ask for an easy one, princess. There is no shame in knowing what you are." He said it almost gently, and the gentleness stung worst of all. Yara looked down at her traitorous, glowing arms and curled her fingers in, as if she could hide the light in her fists.

He walked back to the fire. Yara stood in the dark at the edge of the training ground for a long time, looking at nothing, until she was quite sure her face would behave, and her markings had gone back to their usual traitorous pale.

There is no shame in knowing what you are.

She just wished she knew.

She could not sleep in a new place. She never could. So when the village had gone quiet and the torches in the clearing had burned down to coals, Yara got up from the woven mat in the corner of Oya's hut that was hers now - hers, in a home, in a village, a sentence she kept trying out - and began, very quietly, to unpack. She moved slowly, listening with every breath for her mother's breathing across the hut, half hoping Oya was asleep and half hoping she was not.

Her own things first. Knife. Cloak, folded down small - the light-weave cloak Amara had woven, which bent the light around its wearer the way heat bends the air, and which Yara could use for about as long as she could hold her breath. A change of clothes. Then the bottom of the pack, where her mother had put the things from their old place that were too important to leave.

Her fingers found something she did not know.

It was a charm of carved bone, no longer than her thumb, worn smooth as river stone. A hunter's charm - the kind an elder carves and a healer blesses, that hums, faintly, when prey is near. Even in her hand, at rest, it seemed to hold a warmth the other bone things in the pack did not hold. She had never seen it. She would have remembered this.

Around its edge, in tiny, careful cuts, someone had carved letters. Human letters. Three words.

Jonah Noah Moses.

Yara read them four times.

Her father had had a human name once, before Oya - before everything. In the village he was Ayo, the name her mother had given him, a man's name in her mother's mouth. He had been gone so long that Yara owned only three facts about him: he had laughed at his own terrible Vey'kar clicks, he had loved her mother, and nobody - nobody - would tell her the rest.

"Mother," she said, into the dark of the hut, and her voice came out smaller than she wanted. "Whose is this?" In her lap, her fingers tightened around the charm until its carved edge pressed into her palm. She did not let go of it. She was not sure she could have, even if her mother ordered her to.

Oya was awake. Somehow, Yara understood that her mother had been awake the whole time, listening to her unpack, waiting - or hoping - or dreading. For a long while, she did not answer at all.

Oya did not look up. In the dark her markings were bright enough to see by, though her voice stayed flat and quiet. "Put it back," Oya said at last, quietly. "And sleep, Yara. It is your first night in Kijani." Yara heard what the flatness was holding back - a grief her mother would not name - and it silenced every question crowding her tongue.

Yara put the charm back, exactly where she had found it. Then she lay down on her mat in the dark, in the new village, in her new home, with her father's name buzzing in her head like the charm had tried to hum in her hand. Her eyes stayed open a long time in the dark, listening to the new village breathe around her - hope, homesickness and hurt all tangled together, and underneath them, stubborn as a heartbeat, curiosity about her father's name.

Somebody, she thought, was going to tell her. One day.

End of Chapter 1. Next: Chapter 2 - Yara's first morning in Kijani: Amara's healing hut, Zola's list, and the training ground. Book plan: 20 chapters, about 250 pages - Act 1 is Chapters 1-5, Act 2 is Chapters 6-14, Act 3 is Chapters 15-20.